he was known to the locals as a wheeler-dealer and a skirt chaser. Frieda Bohm, in contrast, was a shy homemaker—she had been quiet and withdrawn ever since her family left Europe—who went through violent mood swings. Her erratic behavior worsened as Bohm grew older; she heard voices, broke a neighbor's nose, and threatened to kill her husband, ultimately ending up in a psychiatric institution. Though David was close with his mother, her frightening behavior forced him to seek refuge in books. Upon discovering science fiction, Bohm was hooked, and his interests steered toward science. Bohm's father had little patience for the "scientism" of his son—when David informed him of the existence of other planets orbiting the Sun, Samuel merely dismissed the fact as irrelevant to the world of human affairs—but he nonetheless paid for Bohm's college education, sending him to Penn State (which was a small rural college at the time, not the enormous state university it is today).

At Penn State, Bohm's brilliance was obvious to his friends and professors alike, as were his personal quirks. Bohm had a "talent for getting people to want to take care of him," according to his friend Melba Phillips—and "a talent for being unhappy." Bohm was continually concerned with his health and suffered from terrible stomachaches from his Penn State days onward. Despite all this, he worked hard and won a spot in the physics PhD program at Caltech upon his graduation from Penn State in 1939. The Pennsylvania immigrants' son had made good: he was at one of the leading centers for physics in the world. But after one semester at Caltech, he became dissatisfied with the course work and research options available. Bohm thought the research being done at Caltech was incremental rather than fundamental, and he found the environment too competitive for his liking. "I wasn't really happy there at Caltech," he recalled later. "They're not interested in science. They were more interested in competition and getting ahead and mastering techniques and so on." Discouraged and uncertain about his future, he went home to Wilkes-Barre for a summer. When he returned to Pasadena in the fall, he became even more unhappy. "In general I was getting a little bit, not exactly depressed, but probably a little low." At a friend's suggestion, Bohm approached a charismatic young visiting professor to ask whether there were any spots open in his research group at Berkeley. By the start of the next semester, Bohm had moved up the California coast to work with his new mentor, J. Robert Oppenheimer.